

The Washington Post

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Democracy Dies in Darkness

SATURDAY, MAY 23, 2026 • \$4

America's newest crop of military officers



KEVIN LAMARQUE/REUTERS

U.S. Naval Academy graduates toss their hats into the air Friday at the conclusion of their graduation and commissioning ceremony in Annapolis, Maryland, where Gen. Dan Caine, chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, served as keynote speaker instead of President Donald Trump, who spoke at the Coast Guard ceremony on Wednesday.

AI leaders: Public dole for masses as jobs fade

Critics question whether billionaires would back funding of welfare state

BY FAIZ SIDDIQUI

Elon Musk has a plan for a future where jobs are wiped out by artificial intelligence: a benevolent government will provide.

"Universal HIGH INCOME via checks issued by the Federal government is the best way to deal with unemployment caused by AI," Musk said in an X post.

Musk has pushed government-issued checks not as a temporary stopgap, but a long-term plan for a world of "amazing abundance" he expects AI to create. "AI/robotics will produce goods & services far in excess of the increase in the money supply," he added, "so there will not be inflation."

Musk is a fierce critic of public spending who has long railed against government largesse. Through his oversight of the U.S. DOGE service, he once sought to cut \$2 trillion from the federal budget. But his latest push proposes a radical expansion of the social safety net — dramatically exceeding Medicare, Medicaid or Social Security.

Musk is among a cohort of tech leaders arguing that AI's coming upheaval may demand massive infusions of cash to everyday Americans — a striking reversal for some tech circles, where many have expressed longstanding hostility to public benefit programs.

Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei has called for similar public-relief measures, including, potentially, universal basic income, or UBI.

Eventually "our current economic setup will no longer make sense," he wrote in a blog post, SEE **SOCIALISM** ON A4

Judge tosses criminal case on Abrego

BY JEREMY ROEBUCK AND MARK BERMAN

A federal judge on Friday dismissed the Justice Department's human-smuggling case against Kilmar Abrego García, ruling that the Trump administration improperly brought it to punish him for successfully challenging his illegal deportation last year.

U.S. District Judge Waverly D. Crenshaw Jr. in Tennessee wrote that "evidence before this Court sadly reflects an abuse of prosecuting power."

The decision delivered an extraordinary defeat for the administration, which marshaled the resources of multiple federal agencies to publicly malign Abrego after court rulings concluded that officials had unlawfully deported him to his native El Salvador, in violation of a 2019 immigration court order.

Crenshaw's ruling also marked the first time a judge validated

Human-smuggling charges ruled vindictive in high-profile legal fight

what has become an increasingly common defense raised by high-profile defendants targeted by the Justice Department in Trump's second term: the claim that they are being prosecuted not in pursuit of justice but rather for political revenge.

In a decision released Friday afternoon, the judge acknowledged the incredibly high bar defendants must meet to warrant a case's dismissal on those grounds. It requires defense attorneys to prove that charges would not have been brought but for improper, vindictive motives on the part of government attorneys.

Crenshaw, who was appointed

by President Barack Obama, wrote that in Abrego's case, it was clear that the investigation into him was tainted "with a vindictive motive."

The judge wrote in a 32-page opinion that while he found "insufficient evidence of actual vindictiveness," he also concluded that the Trump administration "failed to rebut the presumption of vindictiveness."

Crenshaw said he did not reach the conclusion lightly. But the evidence, he wrote, showed that if Abrego had not challenged his deportation, the Trump administration would not have brought this case.

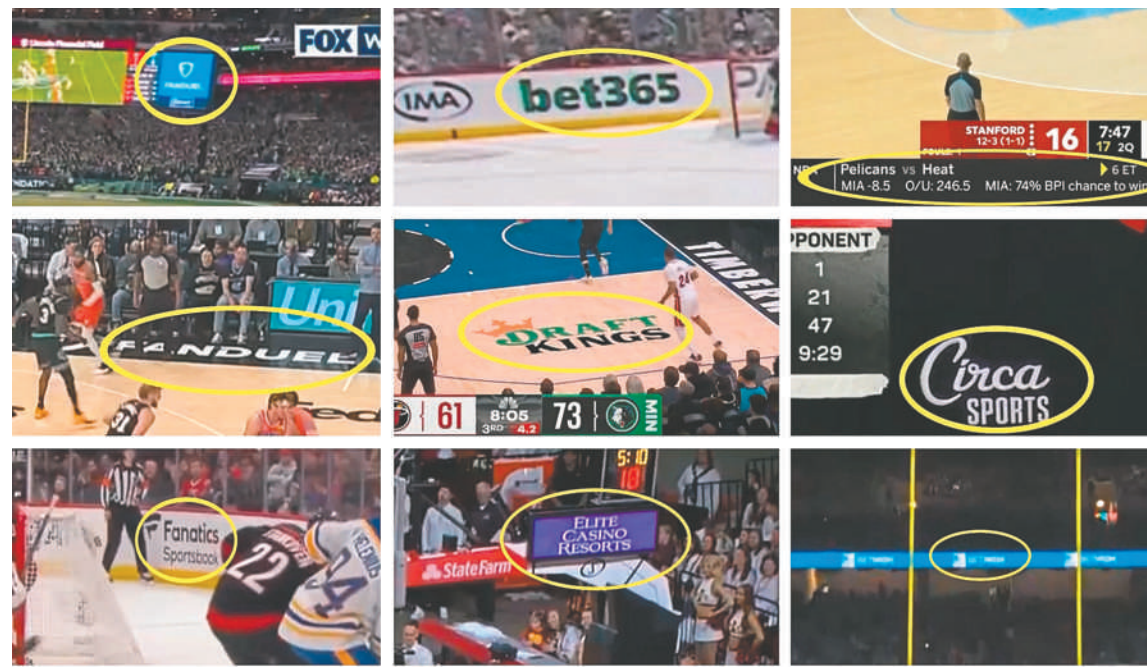
The Justice Department assailed the decision.

"Another activist judge has placed politics above public safety," a spokesperson said in a statement. "The judge's order is wrong and dangerous, and we will appeal."

SEE **ABREGO** ON A2

In 50 hours of TV sports, gambling ads are detected everywhere

Billions of dollars spent yearly by betting companies have profoundly changed the viewing experience, analysis shows



THE WASHINGTON POST/PHOTOS OBTAINED BY THE WASHINGTON POST; ANNOTATIONS BY THE WASHINGTON POST

BY JEREMY B. MERRILL, JONATHAN O'CONNELL AND LUKE CONNORS

A Washington Post analysis of 50 hours of televised football, basketball and hockey games found that betting references have become a ubiquitous part of the viewing experience.

A gambling reference, promotion or commercial occurred every four minutes on average during the segments of professional and college games examined by The Post. Every one of the sporting events had a reference to betting.

The Post developed an artificial intelligence tool to analyze the broadcasts, which were recorded in Washington, D.C. in December and January on six TV channels and one streaming service. The tool searched for promotional lo-

gos and text associated with gambling, however subtle or brief, in nearly 90,000 frames of video. It also found references to betting in the transcribed audio of the games.

The first-of-its-kind analysis demonstrates how billions of dollars in advertising annually by sports betting companies has profoundly changed televised sports in America. While the gambling industry was viewed by professional league owners and the NCAA as a grave threat a little over a decade ago, it is now so integrated with televised sports that it's virtually unavoidable.

The frequency of gambling references The Post found was "incredibly high," said Bob Lynch, founder and chief executive of SponsorUnited, a firm that tracks sports sponsorship data.

Raffaello Rossi, a marketing SEE **GAMBLING** ON A6

SHE CITES HUSBAND'S CANCER DIAGNOSIS

Departure ends a stormy 15-month tenure

BY WARREN P. STROBEL, JOHN HUDSON AND ELLEN NAKASHIMA

Director of National Intelligence Tulsi Gabbard is resigning from the Trump administration, she said Friday, after her husband was diagnosed with an extremely rare bone cancer.

Gabbard informed the White House that June 30 would be her last day as the U.S. intelligence czar.

Her departure ends a stormy 15-month tenure in which the former Democratic congresswoman was largely excluded from President Donald Trump's inner national security circle, even as she pushed his political priorities on election security, declassification and Russia's role in the 2016 presidential contest.

"Unfortunately, I must submit my resignation, effective June 30, 2026. My husband, Abraham, has recently been diagnosed with an extremely rare form of bone cancer," she wrote in a letter to Trump. "At this time, I must step away from public service to be by his side and fully support him through this battle."

Gabbard's husband, Abraham Williams, is a cinematographer. SEE **GABBARD** ON A10

Confidence in economy sinks as costs keep rising

BY OLIVIA GEORGE AND SCOTT CLEMENT

Americans' confidence in the economy has hit a nearly four-year low, according to a new poll, underscoring a growing problem for Republicans ahead of the midterm elections as President Donald Trump struggles to deliver on his campaign pledge to make life more affordable.

Just 16 percent of U.S. adults rate the economy "excellent" or "good," according to the Gallup poll, which was released Friday. An additional 34 percent rate the

economy as "only fair," while 49 percent say it is "poor."

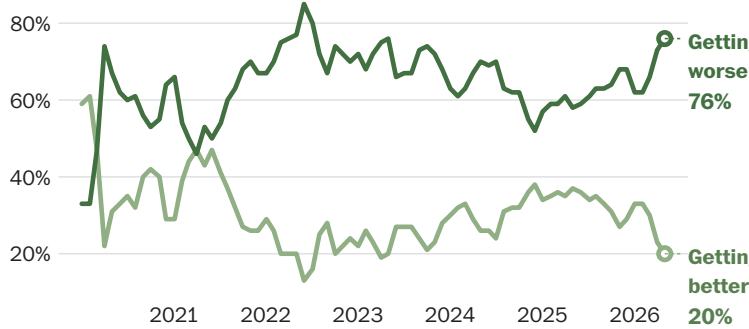
Economic confidence has declined steadily in recent months among Americans across the political spectrum, as the war in Iran drives a sharp increase in inflation and gas prices. Three out of four Americans say economic conditions are getting worse.

While Gallup found that Republicans still remain positive overall, their economic confidence in May reached its lowest since Trump returned to office.

SEE **POLL** ON A2

Economic expectations are the worst since 2022, when inflation was surging

Q: Right now, do you think that economic conditions in the country as a whole are...?



Source: Gallup national polls of U.S. adults; latest survey conducted May 1-17 among 1,001 adults on cellphones and landlines. Error margin +/- 4 points.

IN THE NEWS

Oil drilling plan A draft proposal would allow for drilling off the California and Florida coasts, including two of the largest areas used for ocean-based military training. A16

Colbert final The host wrapped up an 11-year run with surprise celebrity guests, a visit from his late-night peers and multiple songs. B1

THE NATION At a New York rally, the president touted an economic message he hopes will resonate. A3
A record 860,000 fireworks are planned for Trump's July Fourth show in Washington. A5

THE WORLD U.K. police urged new witnesses to speak out in the probe of former prince Andrew. A11
NATO allies are grappling with the U.S. pull-back and confusion over its military plans. A12

THE ECONOMY Kevin Warsh was sworn in as Federal Reserve chair at a White House ceremony, facing surging inflation fueled by war in Iran weighing on Americans. A13
Wall Street continues to rise, even as U.S. households keep getting more discouraged. A13

STYLE This year at Cannes, which is known for celebrating grandes dames, all the best-dressed women were over 50. B1
SPORTS Nationals starter Cade Cavalli is using a neuromuscular machine in an extensive routine after Tommy John surgery. B7

THE REGION A federal judge ordered White House offices to comply with the Presidential Records Act, established after the Watergate scandal. B12
In the D.C. mayoral race, praise for indicted lawmaker Trayon White Sr. is prompting some careful tiptoeing. B12

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